

LITTLE SPROUT STORIES

Sophie & James Visit the Repair Shop

A story about feeling sad — and learning that fixed things tell a story



James carried his favorite toy robot the whole way, cradled in both arms like something made of glass. The robot’s arm hung crooked and still — no waving, no marching, no beep-boop hello. “Today David the repair helper will try to fix him,” James said, half hopeful, half holding his breath.

James’s robot is broken.



The repair shop smelled of wood and warm metal, and David looked up from his workbench with a kind smile. James set the robot down gently, then asked the question that had been sitting in his tummy all morning: “Will it be exactly like before?” he asked, worried. “Exactly the same as he was?”

James is worried.



“Before I fix anything,” said David, “a repairer gets ready.” Click went the lights. Swish went the broom. Then he laid his tools along the bench in a careful row — screwdrivers big to small, pliers, glue, a clamp — and checked the shelf of things waiting their turn: a lamp, a toaster, a wobbly stool. “My first job isn’t fixing,” David said. “It’s knowing what is waiting, and having the right tool ready for it.”

David gets his tools ready.



David switched on his magnifying lamp, and the robot’s arm grew big and clear as a moon. He peered, he wiggled, he tested. “I can fix it,” he said at last. “The glue will hold, and I will reinforce it — make it strong. But I must tell you honestly, James: you might still see the repair line.” James looked at his robot, and his shoulders sank.

James feels sad.

How does James feel?

- ◯ Happy
- ◯ Sad
- ◯ Excited



Sophie squeezed his hand. “When my teddy’s ear got sewn back,” she said, “it didn’t look the same. It looked… loved. Sometimes fixed things get a new kind of special.” James thought about the teddy’s brave, crooked ear. He nodded, just a little.

Fixed things can be special.



“Before I touch a treasure,” David said, “I practice.” He showed them his practice shelf: a chair leg he had glued and re-glued while he was learning, and a row of scrap wood, dotted with test drops of glue. “Fixers practice on scraps that belong to nobody,” he explained, “so that when a beloved thing lands on the bench, our hands already know exactly what to do.”

David practices on old wood first.



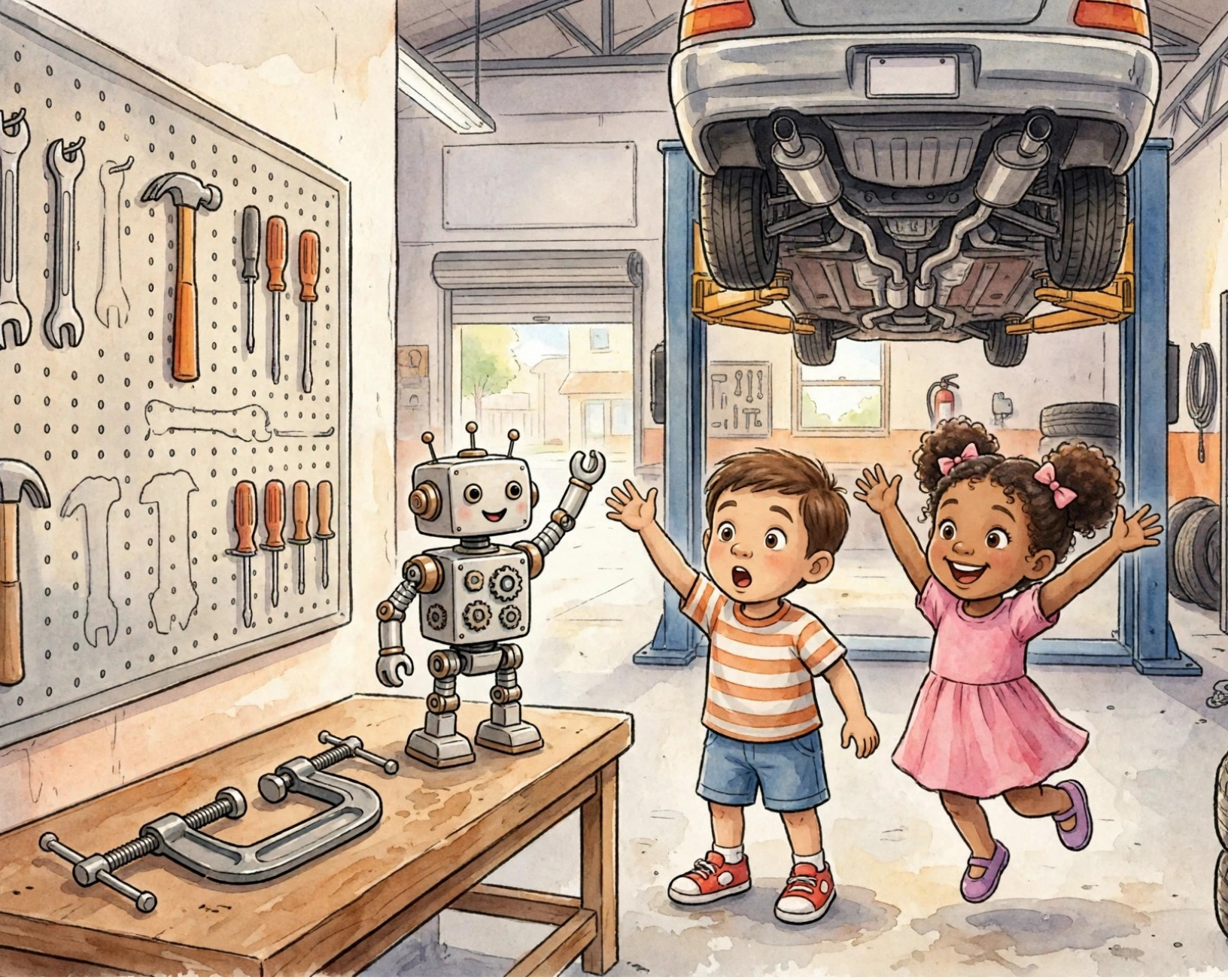
While they waited, David pointed along the waiting shelf, and every broken thing had a story. “That lamp belongs to the library, so children can read after dark. That bicycle gets Mr. Okafor to work. That toaster makes breakfast for a whole family.” He smiled. “A repair shop doesn’t just fix things. It keeps the whole neighborhood’s things working — and keeps good things out of the trash.”

David fixes things for the whole town.



Now David worked slowly, the way surgeons and storytellers work — no rushing allowed. A bead of glue along the break. The little arm held gently in place. The clamp closed like a patient hand, squeezing while the glue set strong. James watched every single step, barely breathing, while Sophie counted the clamp’s slow ticking seconds out loud.

David fixes the arm.



When the clamp opened — click — a thin seam ran across the robot’s shoulder, like a tiny silver river on a map. James held his breath. Then the arm went up. The arm went down. The arm waved — beep-boop! — in a perfect, marching wave.

The robot can wave again.



James looked at the seam for a long, long moment. Then the grin arrived, wide and proud. “That’s not a mistake,” he announced. “That’s his battle scar now. It shows he broke — and he got fixed — and he’s still him.” He pressed the button, and the robot marched in a proud little circle, seam shining.

James feels proud.

How does James feel about the seam by the end?

- ◯ Upset
- ◯ Proud
- ◯ Confused



“You know my favorite part of this job?” David said, wiping his hands. “It isn’t the glue, and it isn’t the tools. It’s this moment — when a loved thing goes home again, carrying its story on the outside. Everything I’ve ever fixed left here a little bit different, and every single bit of different was a story.”

Fixed things tell a story.



Sophie and James thanked David a hundred times, and the robot waved one more beep-boop goodbye all on its own — well, almost. “And we promise,” said James, hugging his battle-scarred best friend, “anything else that breaks, we bring it straight to you.” “I’ll be here,” said David. “Bench ready.”

They say, “Thank you, David!”



■ Repair Shop Explorer

Great reading!

For Grown-Ups

Feeling/skill: Small grief eases when a repaired thing is seen as changed, not ruined.

Ask your child: Has something you loved ever broken and gotten fixed?

Try this: Fix something small together and talk about its new marks.

Words to grow on: cradled, crooked, honestly, magnifying, reinforce, seam, practice, beloved, proud. Point at the tools as you name them — screwdriver, pliers, glue, clamp, magnifying lamp.

The bigger picture: Repairers do much more than fix the one thing in front of them — they open the shop and prepare their tools each day, practice new repairs on scraps before touching anything precious, tell the truth about what a repair can and cannot do, and keep a whole neighborhood’s belongings working longer instead of being thrown away.

Standards: RI.K.8, L.K.4.a

The End — thanks for reading!